THE MANUAL YOU NEVER OPENED

17 Claude guides that put you ahead of 95% of users

Every cookbook, prompting guide and course Anthropic publishes.

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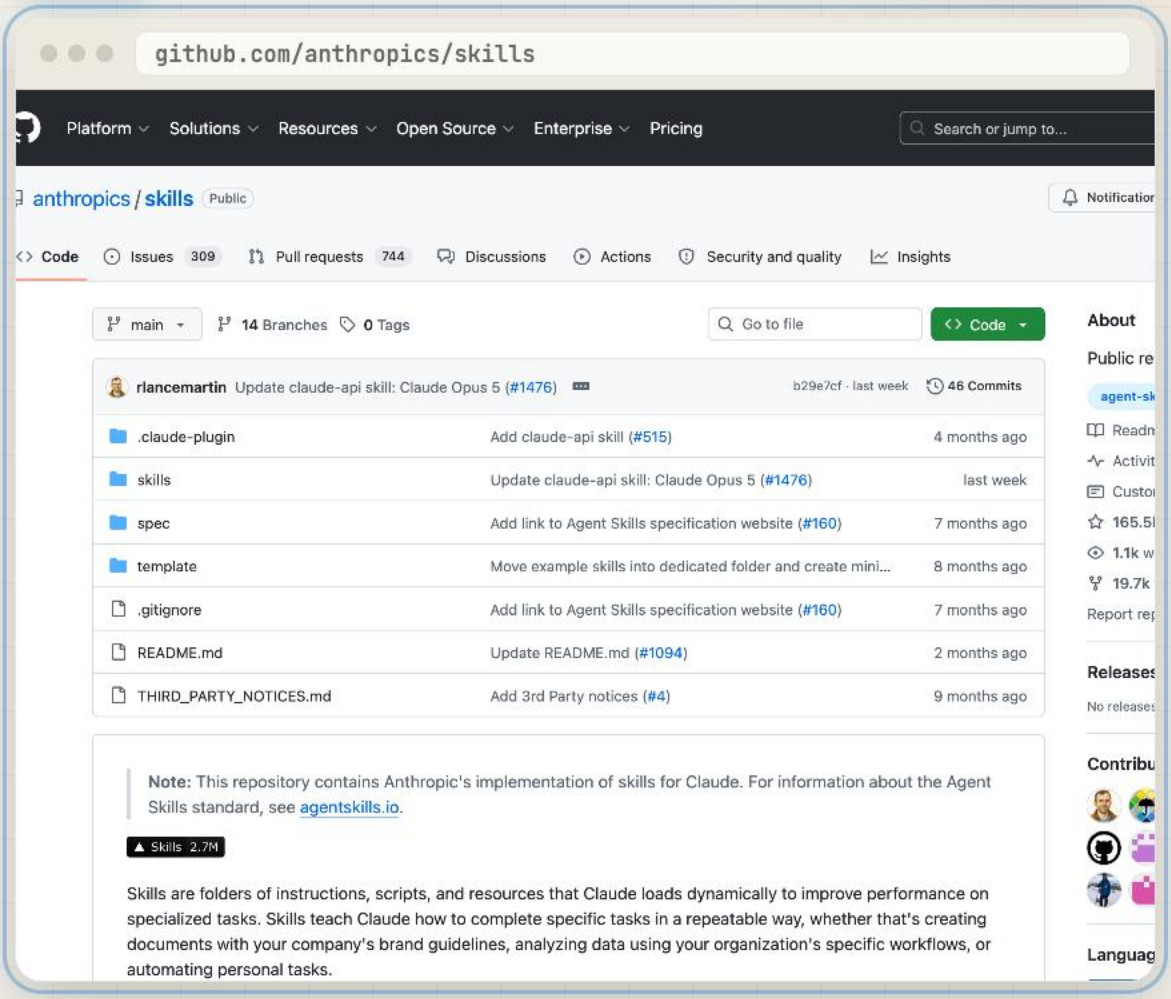
CHARLIE HILLS · charliehills.substack.com

THE COOKBOOKS ★ 165.5k

01 Agent Skills



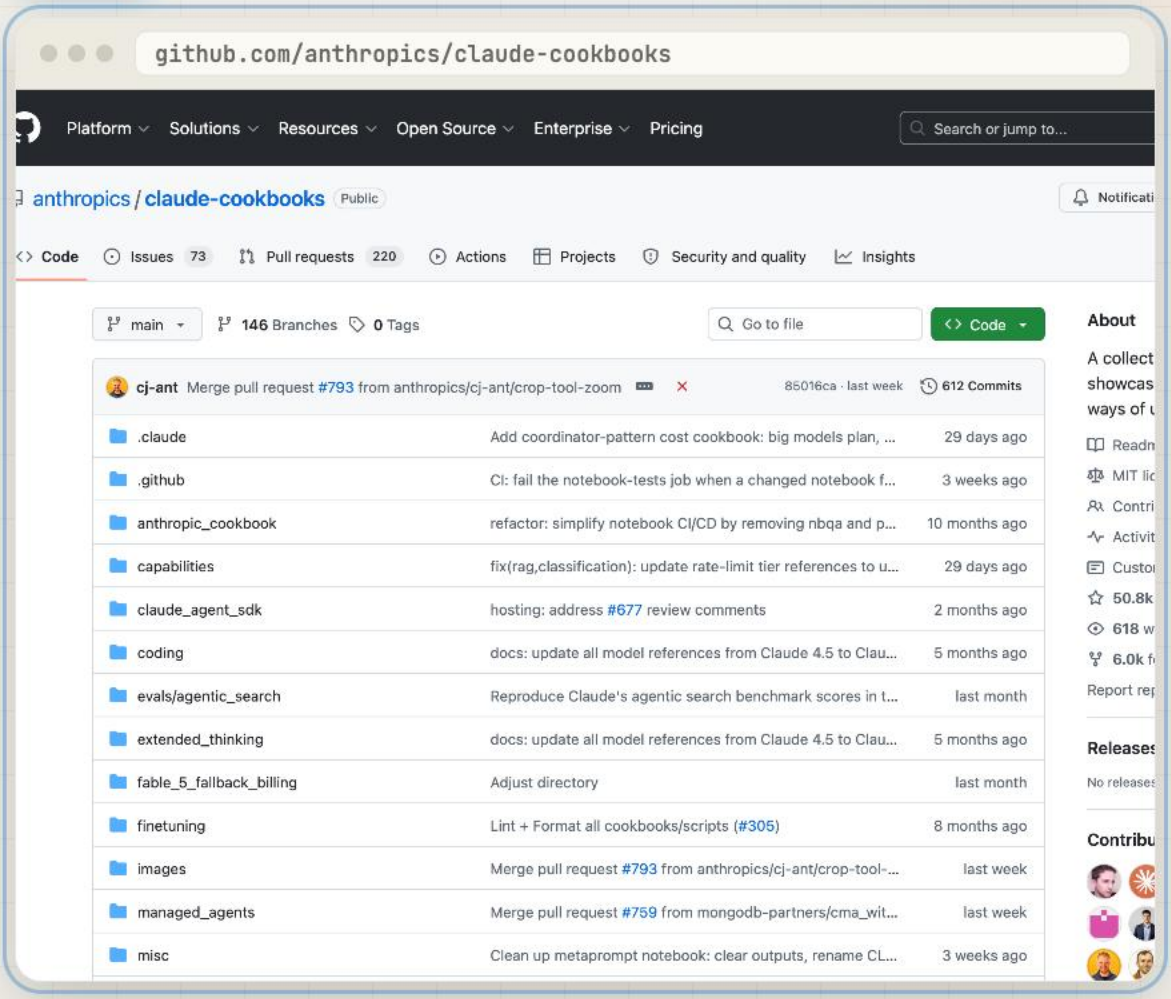
WHAT IT IS **Anthropic's own skills, including the ones that build Word, Excel, PowerPoint and PDF files.**

START HERE

Clone the repo, drop one folder into your skills directory, Claude uses it on the next prompt.

THE COOKBOOKS ★ 50.8k

02 Claude Cookbooks



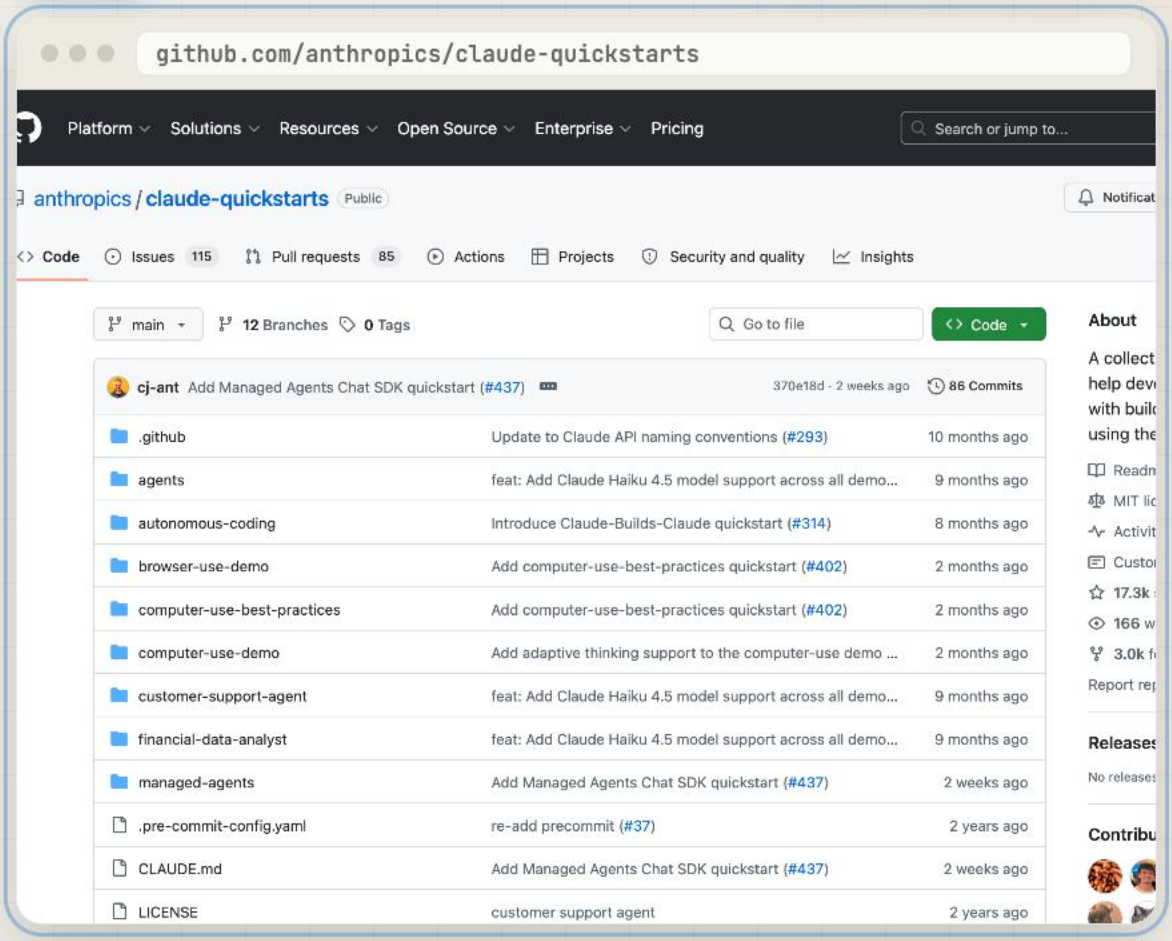
WHAT IT IS **Ready-made recipes for classification, summarising, RAG, vision, tool use and prompt caching.**

START HERE

Open the notebook closest to your job and change the prompt at the top. Nothing else.

THE COOKBOOKS ★ 17.3k

03 Claude Quickstarts

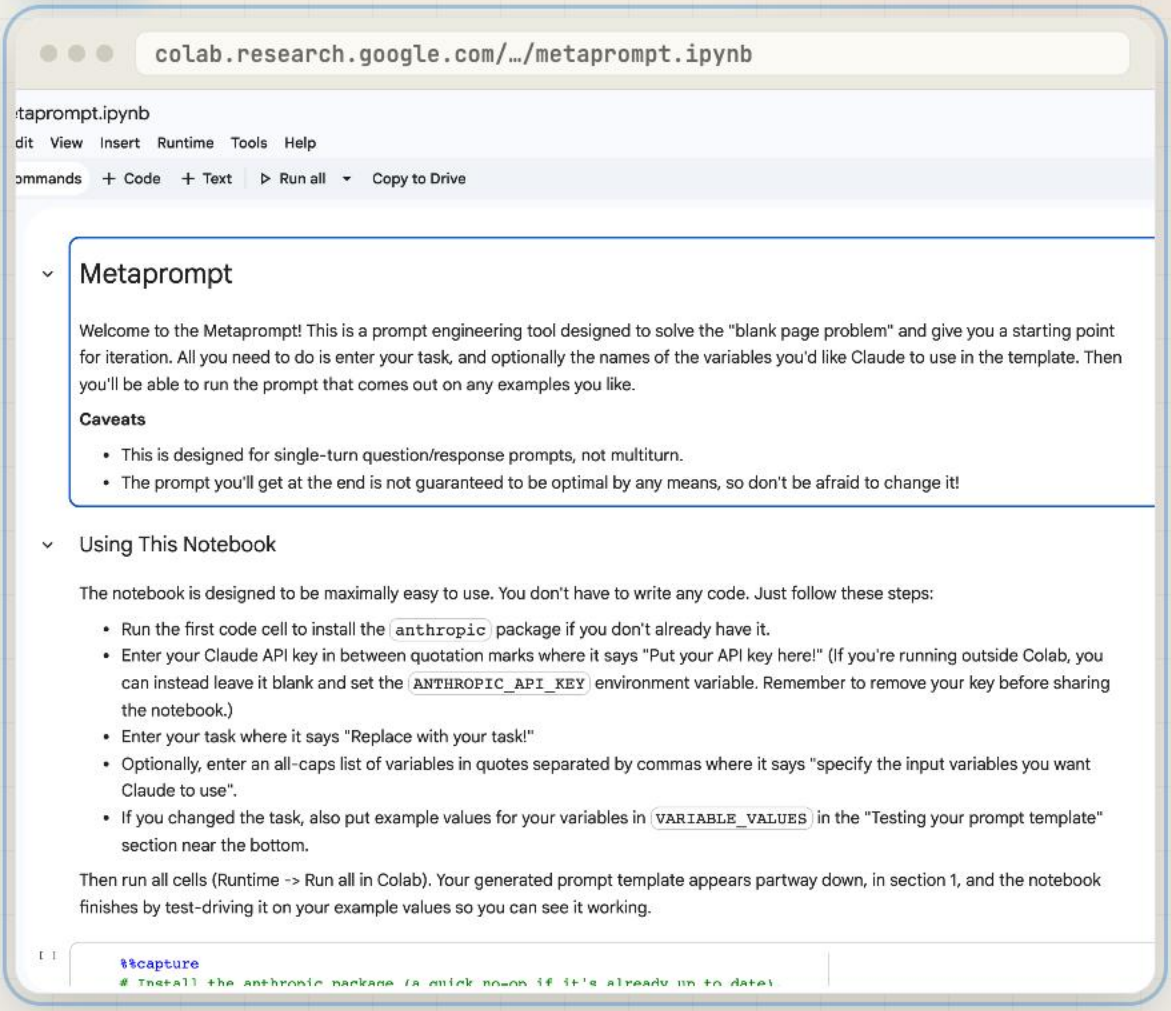


WHAT IT IS Seven complete apps you can run: customer support agent, financial analyst, browser automation, autonomous coder.

START HERE

Start with the customer support agent. It runs locally in about ten minutes.

04 The Metaprompt



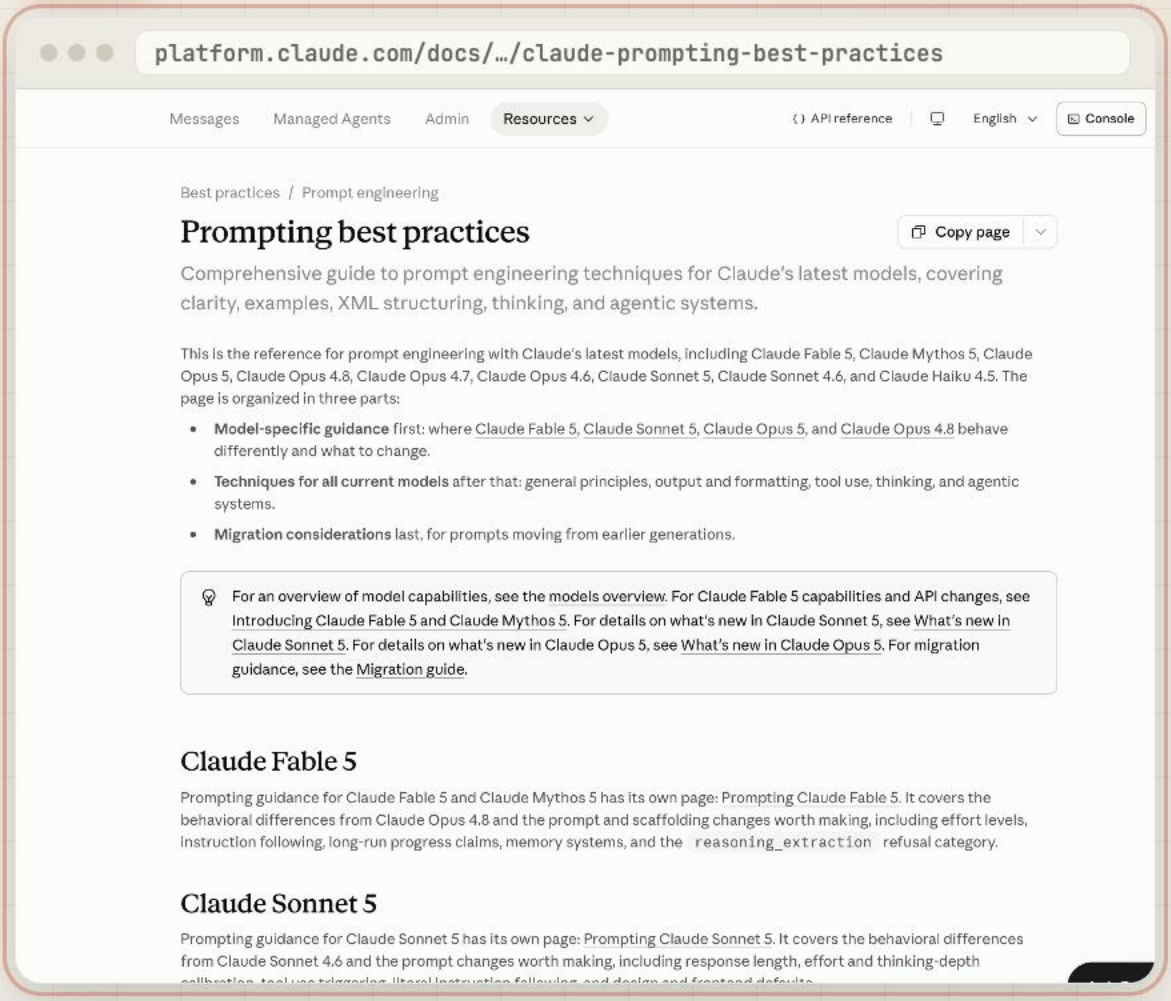
WHAT IT IS No idea how to start a prompt? This one writes your first draft for you.

START HERE

Paste your rough idea into the top cell, run it, keep the draft it hands back.

THE PROMPTING GUIDES START HERE

05 Prompting best practices



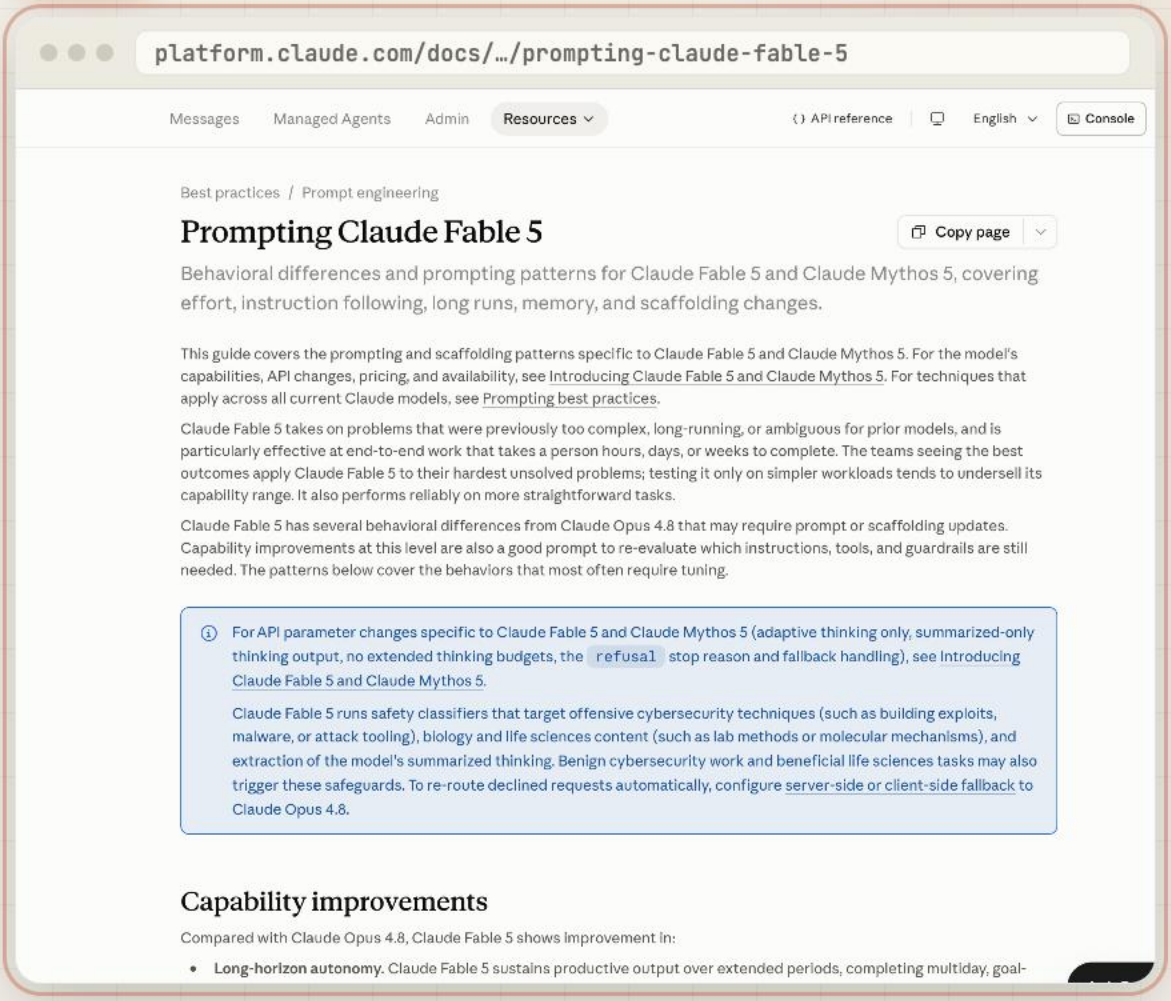
WHAT IT IS The living reference. Clarity, examples, XML, roles, thinking, tool use, agents.

START HERE

Read it once end to end, then keep the tab open the next time you write a real prompt.

THE PROMPTING GUIDES MOST CAPABLE

06 Prompting Fable 5



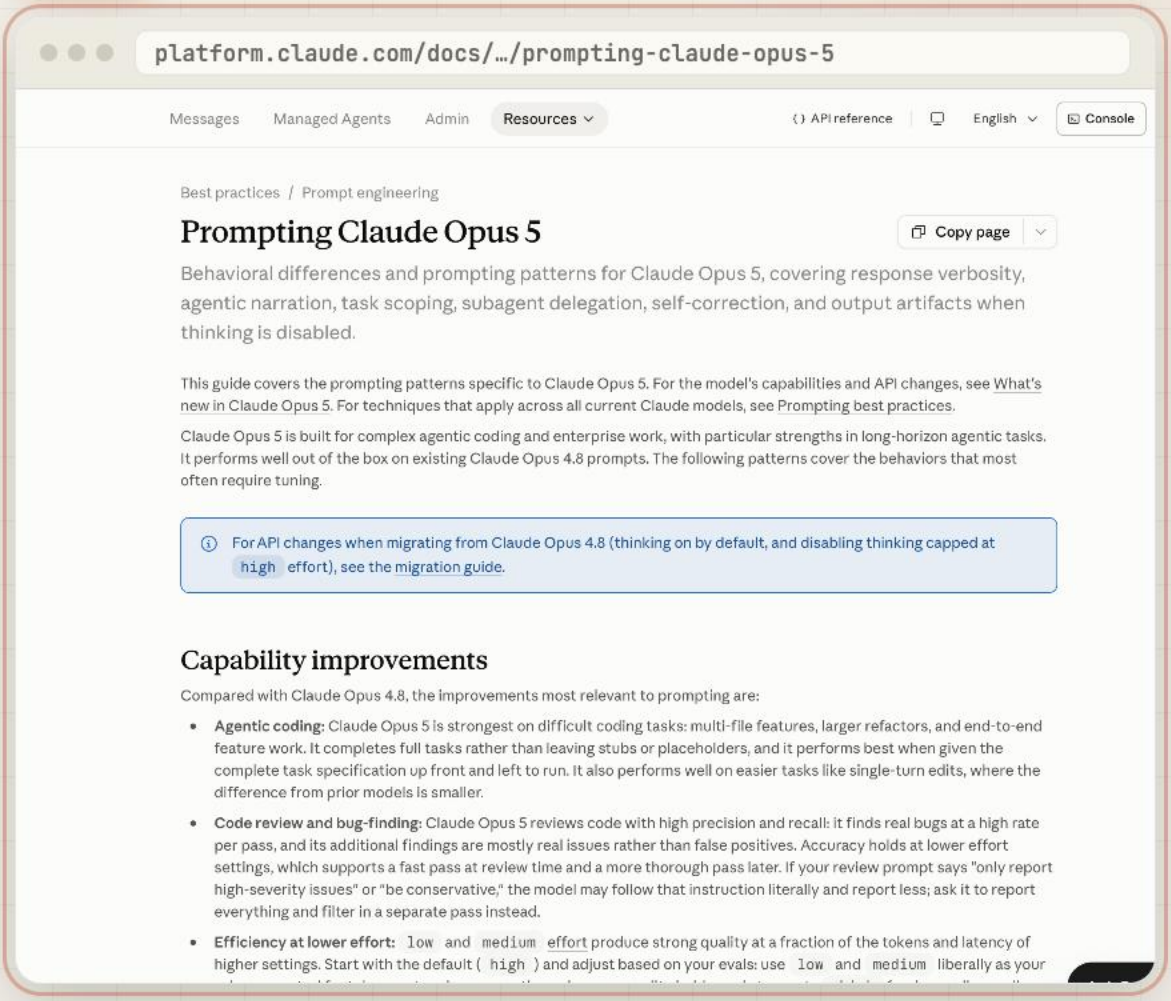
WHAT IT IS **The most capable model Anthropic has released, and what to change in your prompts for it.**

START HERE

Read it before you hand Fable your hardest job. It prompts differently to the rest.

THE PROMPTING GUIDES THE DEFAULT

07 Prompting Opus 5


platform.claude.com/docs/…/prompting-claude-opus-5

Messages Managed Agents Admin Resources API reference English Console

Best practices / Prompt engineering

Prompting Claude Opus 5

Copy page

Behavioral differences and prompting patterns for Claude Opus 5, covering response verbosity, agentic narration, task scoping, subagent delegation, self-correction, and output artifacts when thinking is disabled.

This guide covers the prompting patterns specific to Claude Opus 5. For the model's capabilities and API changes, see What's new in Claude Opus 5. For techniques that apply across all current Claude models, see Prompting best practices.

Claude Opus 5 is built for complex agentic coding and enterprise work, with particular strengths in long-horizon agentic tasks. It performs well out of the box on existing Claude Opus 4.8 prompts. The following patterns cover the behaviors that most often require tuning.

For API changes when migrating from Claude Opus 4.8 (thinking on by default, and disabling thinking capped at `high` effort), see the migration guide.

Capability improvements

Compared with Claude Opus 4.8, the improvements most relevant to prompting are:

- **Agentic coding:** Claude Opus 5 is strongest on difficult coding tasks: multi-file features, larger refactors, and end-to-end feature work. It completes full tasks rather than leaving stubs or placeholders, and it performs best when given the complete task specification up front and left to run. It also performs well on easier tasks like single-turn edits, where the difference from prior models is smaller.
- **Code review and bug-finding:** Claude Opus 5 reviews code with high precision and recall: it finds real bugs at a high rate per pass, and its additional findings are mostly real issues rather than false positives. Accuracy holds at lower effort settings, which supports a fast pass at review time and a more thorough pass later. If your review prompt says "only report high-severity issues" or "be conservative," the model may follow that instruction literally and report less; ask it to report everything and filter in a separate pass instead.
- **Efficiency at lower effort:** `low` and `medium` effort produce strong quality at a fraction of the tokens and latency of higher settings. Start with the default (`high`) and adjust based on your evals: use `low` and `medium` liberally as your

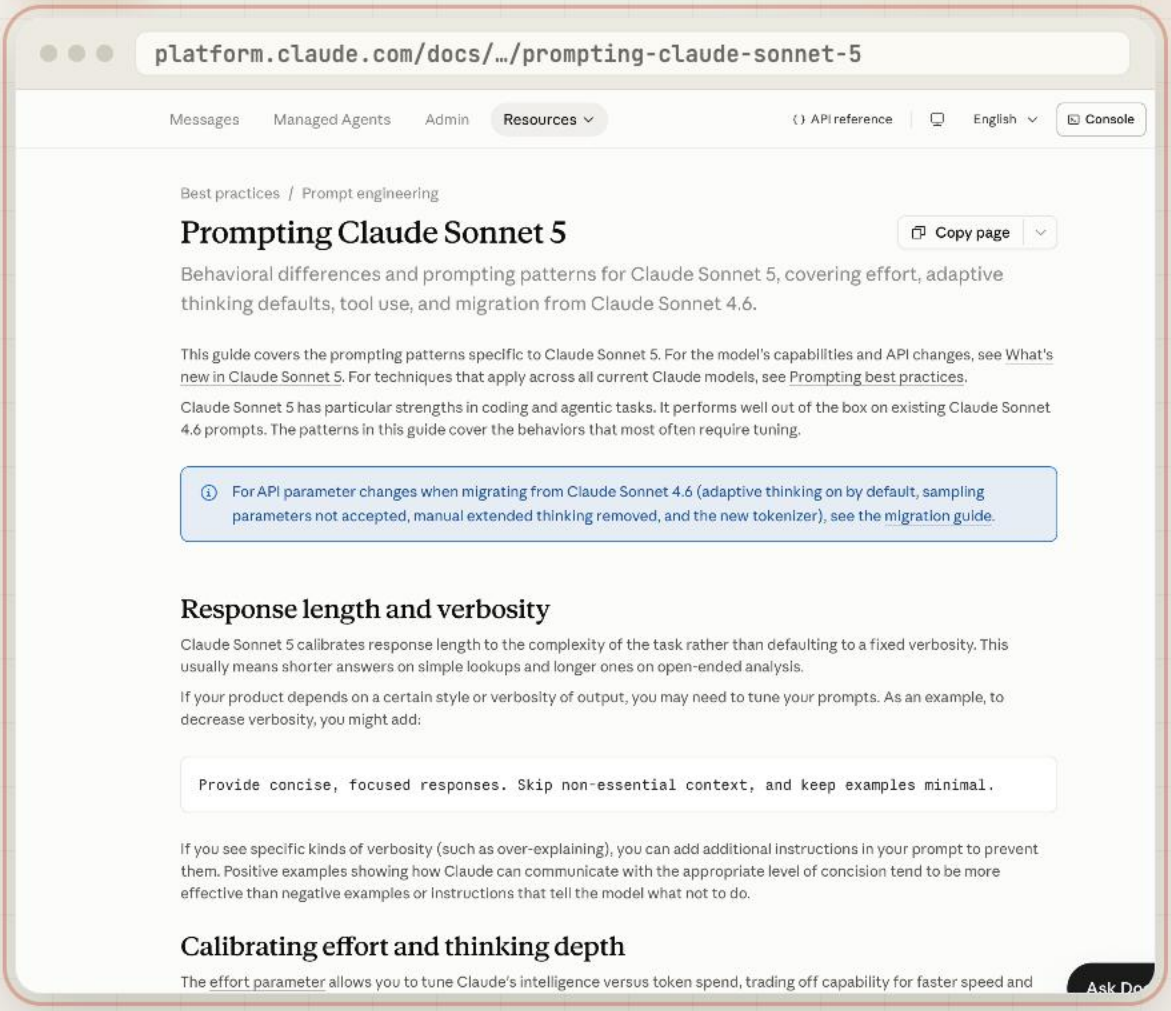
WHAT IT IS **The model Anthropic tells you to start on. Built for agentic work and heavy lifting.**

START HERE

Match your prompts to this page before blaming the model for a weak answer.

THE PROMPTING GUIDES

08 Prompting Sonnet 5



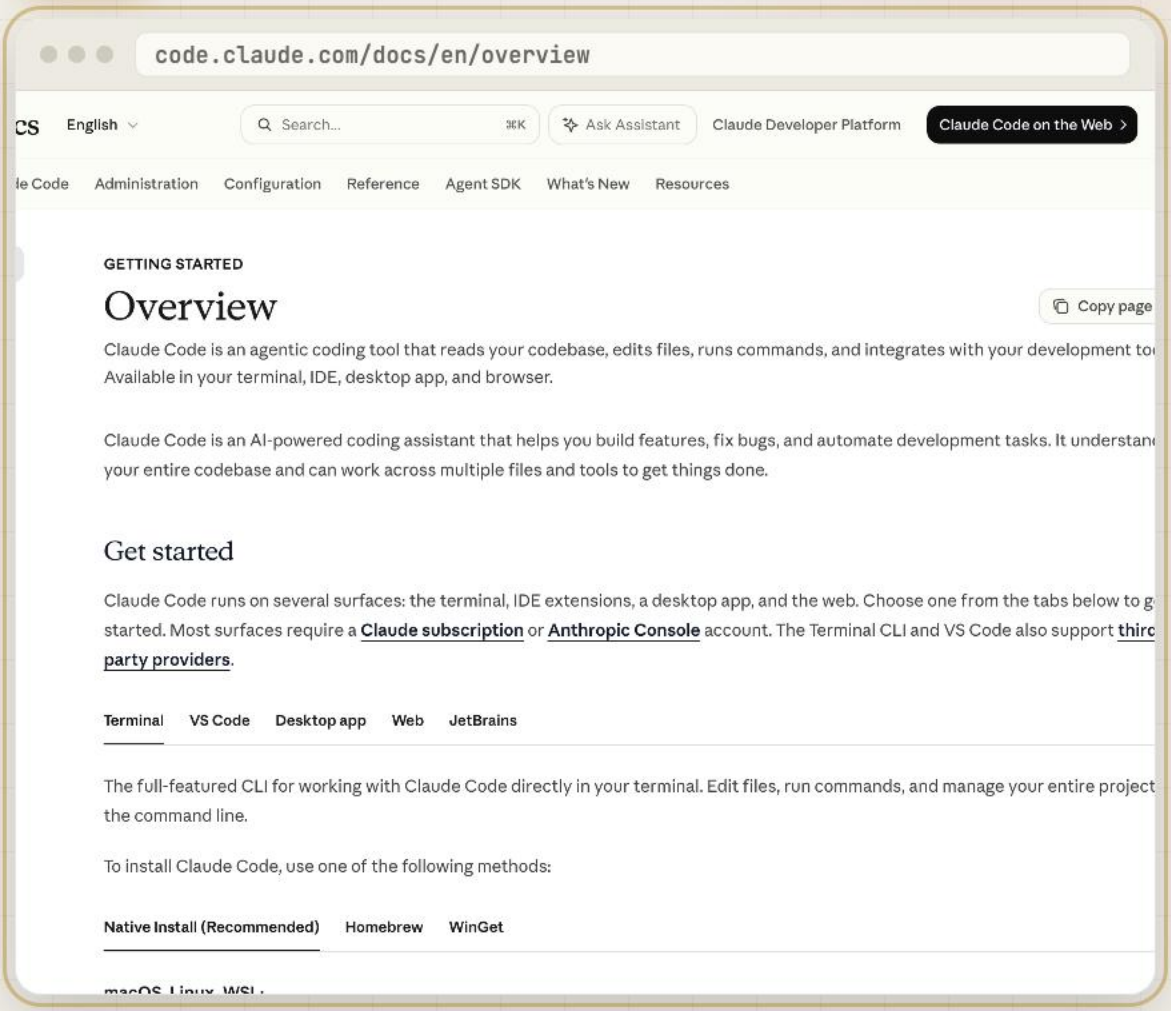
WHAT IT IS **The speed-and-brains pick, and where most of your daily work should sit.**

START HERE

Move your everyday prompts here first. You will notice the speed before the cost.

CLAUDE CODE

09 Claude Code docs



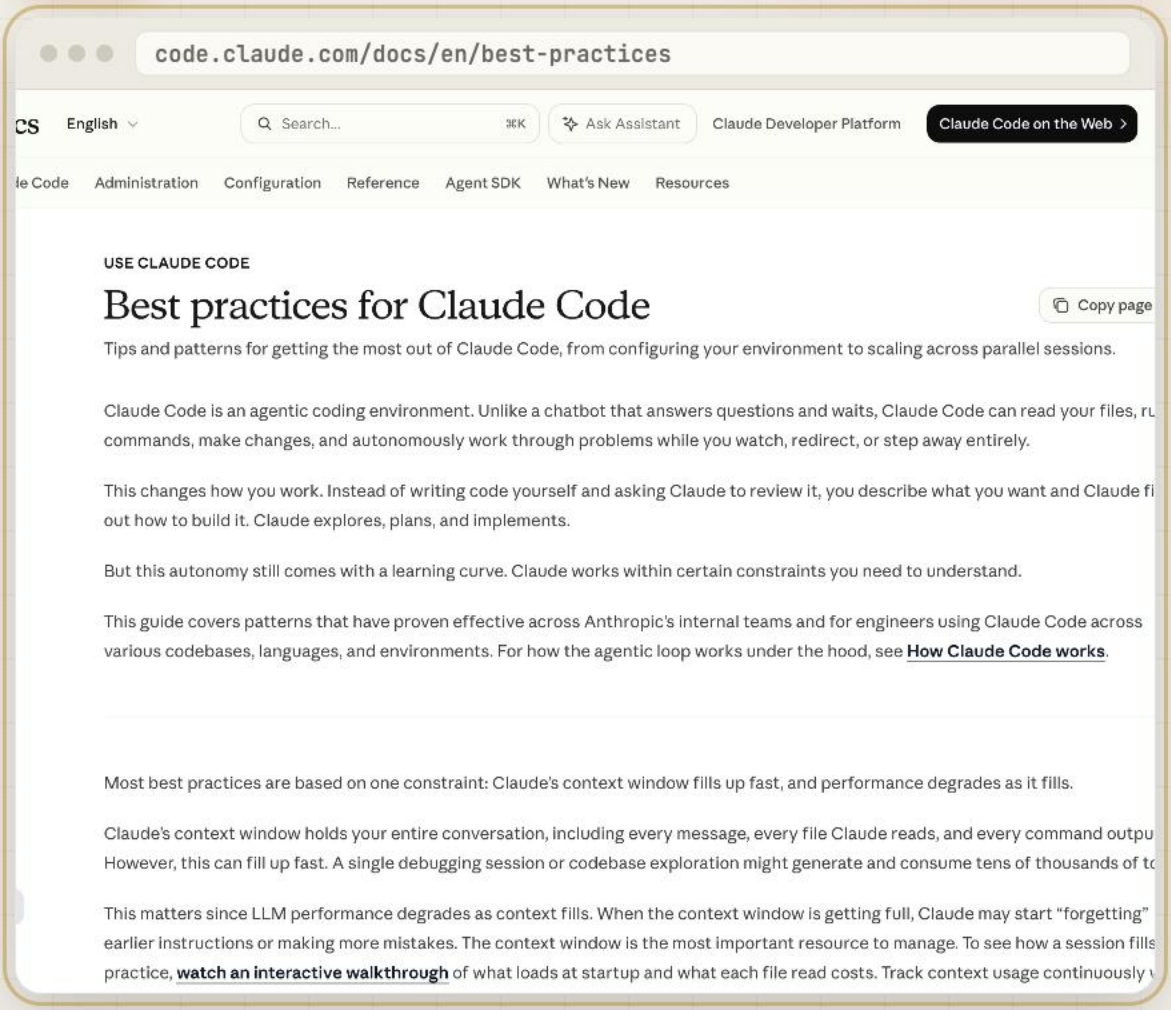
WHAT IT IS The full manual for the version of Claude that runs in your terminal.

START HERE

Skim the overview, then run /init inside a project folder and read what it writes.

CLAUDE CODE

10 Claude Code best practices



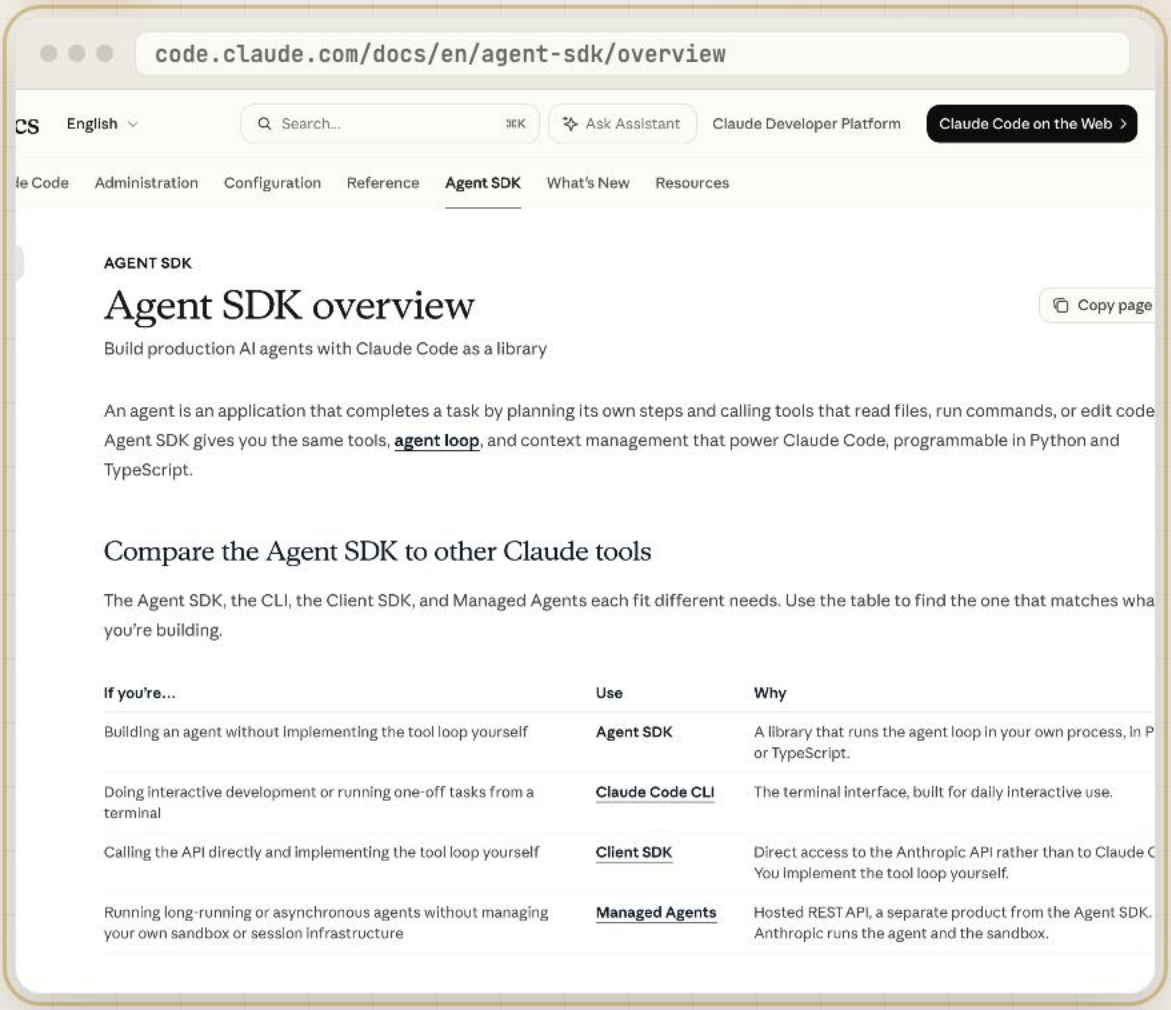
WHAT IT IS **Verify-your-work loops, plan mode, CLAUDE.md, subagents and parallel sessions.**

START HERE

Copy the CLAUDE.md pattern into your own project first. It changes every session after it.

CLAUDE CODE

11 Agent SDK



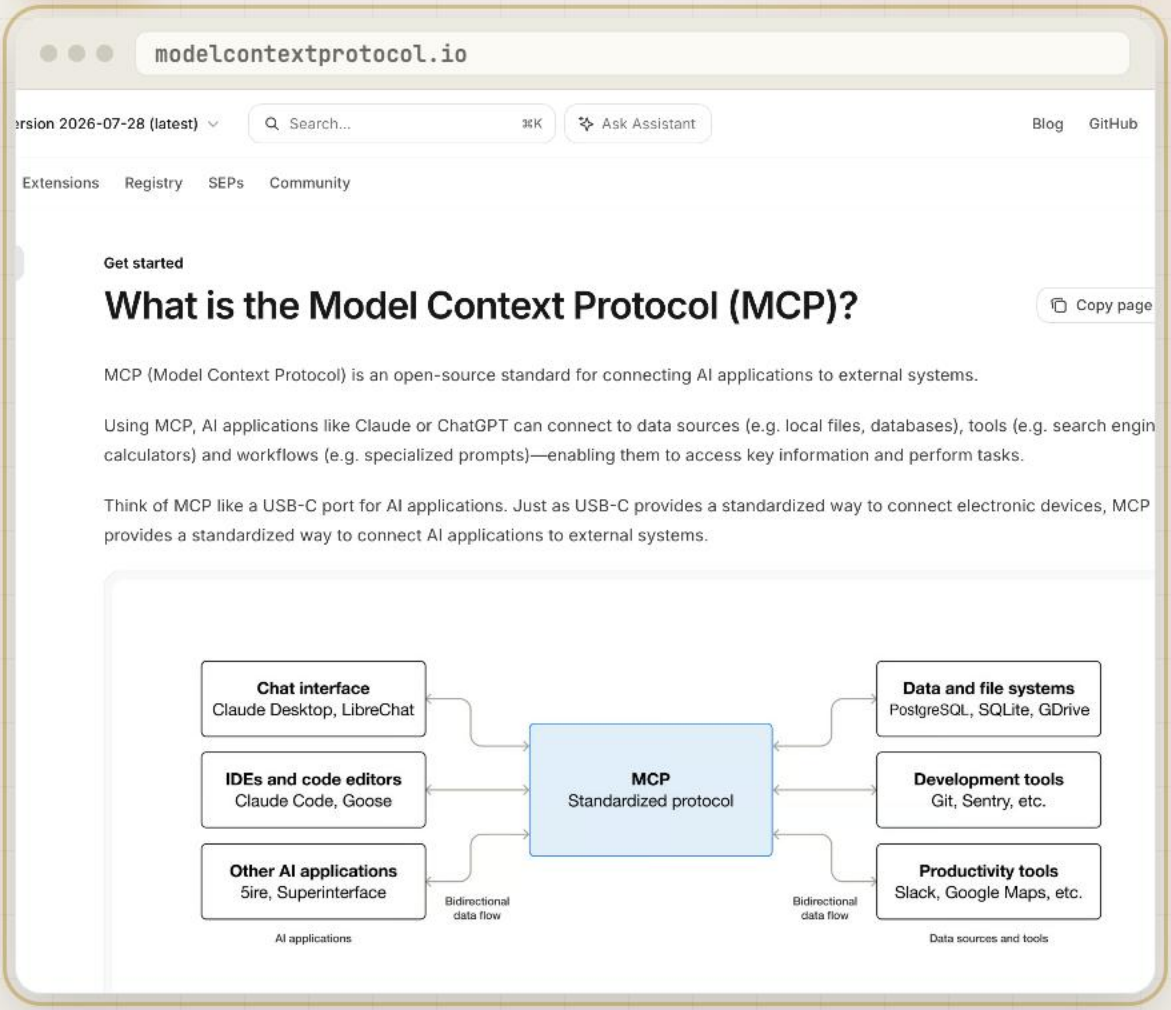
WHAT IT IS Build your own agents on the same harness Claude Code runs on.

START HERE

Read the overview to see what an agent actually needs before you try to build one.

CLAUDE CODE

12 MCP docs



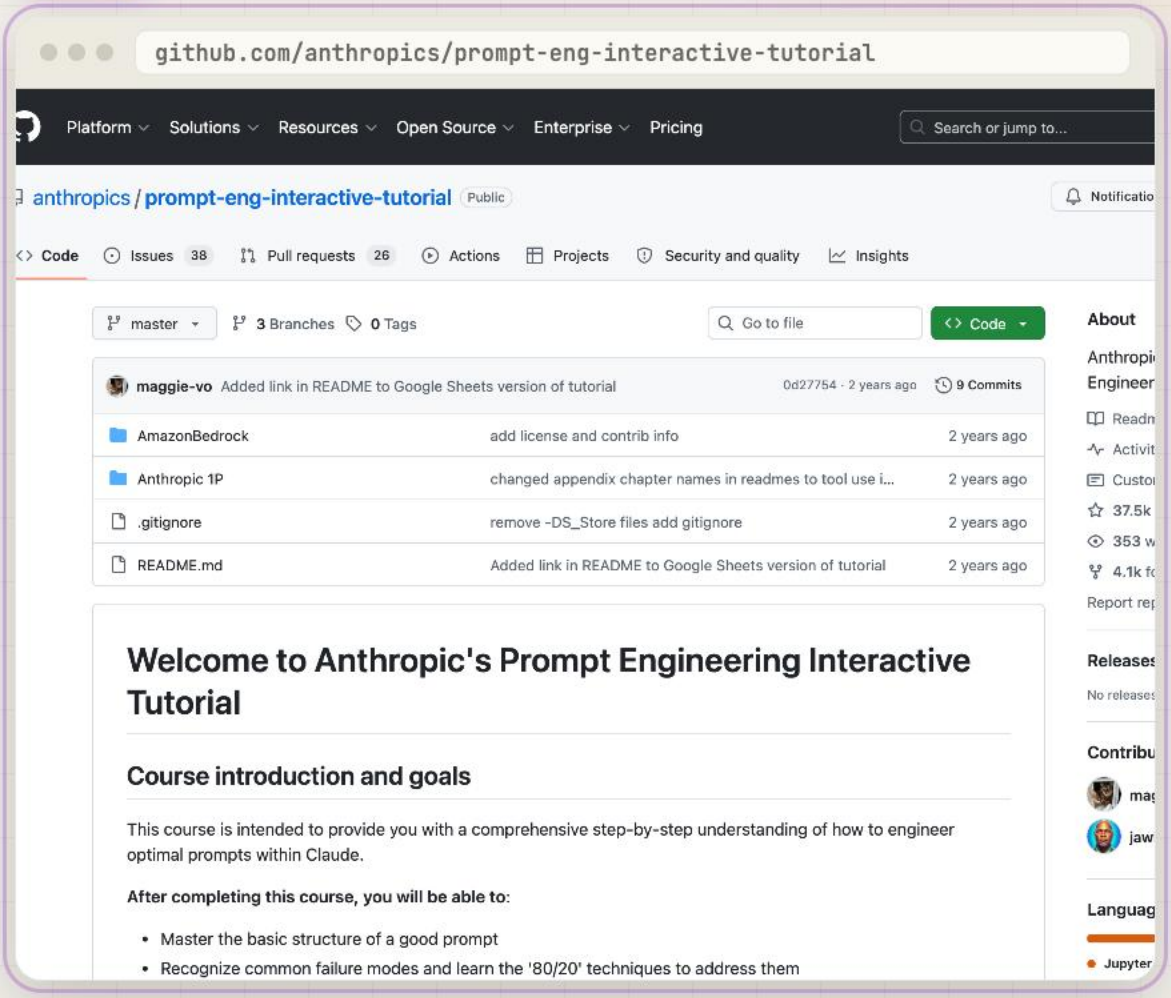
WHAT IT IS Wire Claude into your own tools and data, so it reads live instead of guessing.

START HERE

Connect one tool you already live in, Notion or Drive, and stop there for a week.

THE COURSES ★ 37.5k

13 Interactive tutorial



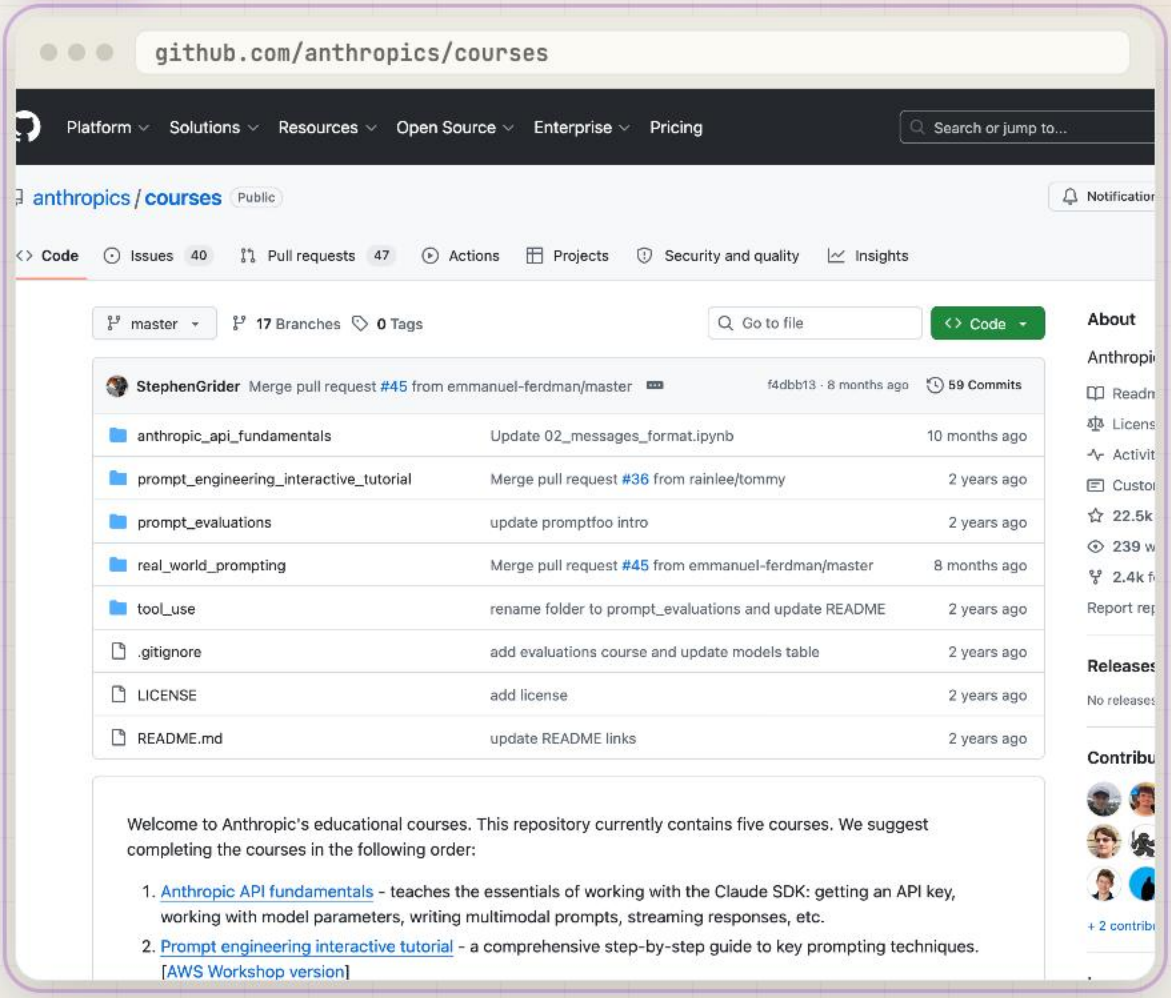
WHAT IT IS Nine chapters, beginner to advanced, with exercises you actually do.

START HERE

Do chapters one and two today. They take about twenty minutes together.

THE COURSES ★ 22.5k

14 Anthropic Courses



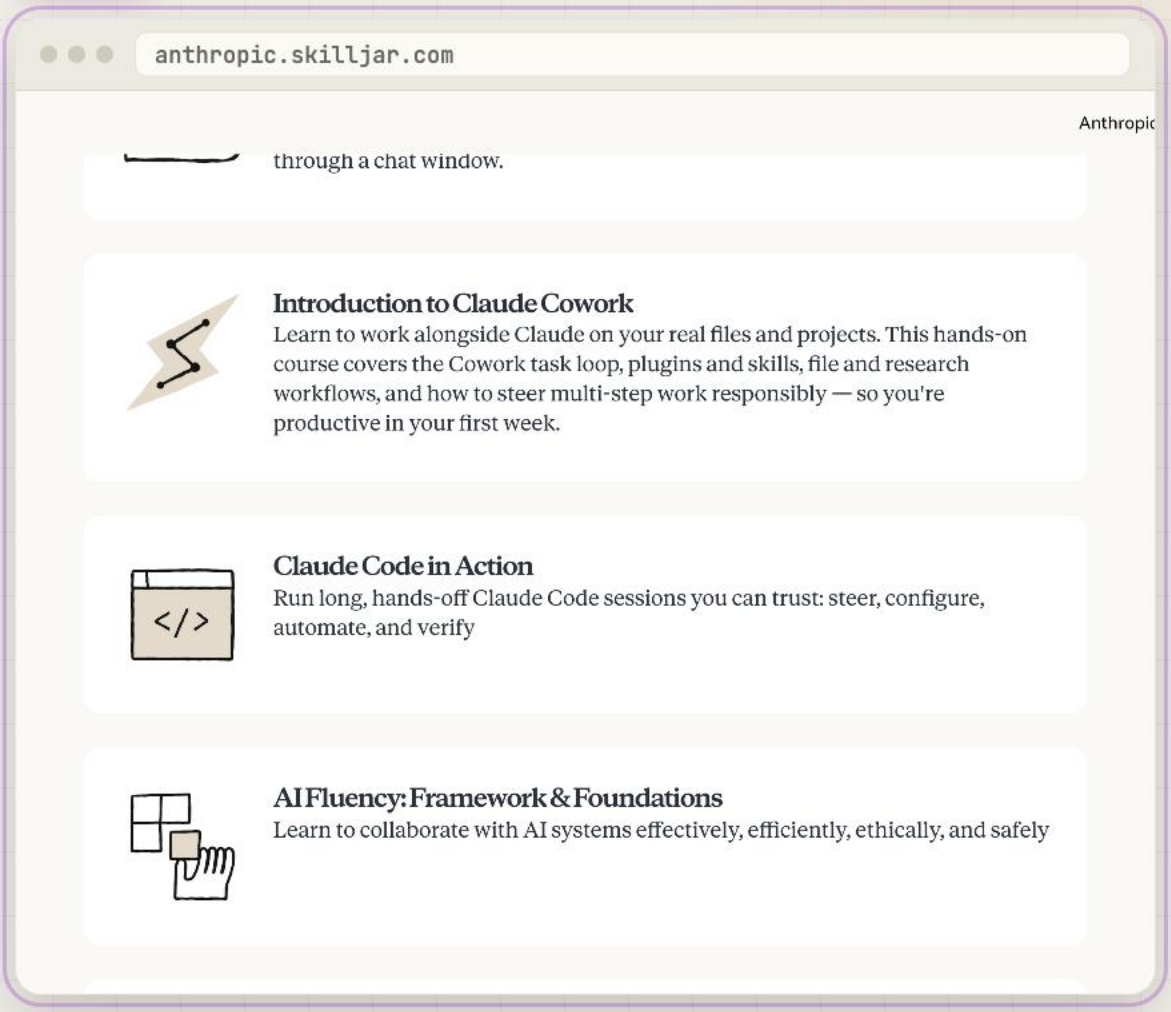
WHAT IT IS **Five full courses: API fundamentals, prompting, real-world prompting, evaluations, tool use.**

START HERE

Start on the prompting course. Skip the API one unless you write code.

THE COURSES

15 Anthropic Academy



WHAT IT IS **Anthropic's own course platform, including Claude Code in Action, agent skills and MCP.**

START HERE

Sign in and take Claude Code in Action first. It is the one that changes how you work.

THE ENGINEERING WRITE-UPS

16 Building effective agents

WHAT IT IS The five workflow patterns, named and drawn. Prompt chaining, routing, parallelisation, orchestrator-workers, evaluator-optimiser.

START HERE

Read the five and name the one your current workflow already is.

THE ENGINEERING WRITE-UPS

17 Context engineering

WHAT IT IS **Why long chats get worse, and the three fixes: compaction, notes, sub-agents.**

START HERE

Apply the three fixes the next time a long chat starts drifting off the brief.